

Sahara naal therinjitta vaazhara naal narahamayidum (If you know when you will die, life will be hell)

Sivaji, 2007

Niveditha believes it is his body language, which is childlike and comic. Add to that the Robin Hood character he has played repeatedly. It is an archetype *Sivaji* has reinforced, with a mind-boggling use of technology and ingenuity. He plays an NRI software engineer who ploughs his fortune into a Rs 200-crore super-speciality hospital for the poor but runs up against the system: Adishesan (Telugu star Suman, portly and unrecognisable), a powerful education baron sits on a mountain of money earned through capitation fees which feeds corrupt ministers and government employees. The moderniser is defeated and cast on to the streets—the villain tauntingly tells him that he would not even qualify as a bus conductor and gives him a one rupee coin. Rajnikant rebounds from the pavement, courtesy the rupee coin which he routinely flips to play out Shankar's enduring icon—the people's saviour, in

Koodai Sunlight, shot outside the magnificent Frank Gehry-designed Guggenheim museum in Bilbao, cost Rs 18 crore. The movie used 600 computer graphic shots spread over 50 minutes of the film and premiered several technologies such as roller vision camera, helium balloon lights and D1 negative 4K resolution.

Rajnikant is now immersed in working on his daughter's animated film, which the family hopes will extend his legacy—the attempt is to make the Sultan character 25 years younger than the real Rajnikant. Will this give the star enough time for politics, his perennial potential profession? There are enough hints of his readiness to take on MGR's mantle in the movies but does it extend to politics? In the 1996 polls, Rajnikant spoke against J. Jayalalithaa and expressed support for the DMK-TMC combine, which then won the elections. In 2003, when the entire Tamil film world protested against Karnataka's refusal to share Cauvery river waters with Tamil

Nadu, at Neyveli, Rajnikant stayed away from it—he instead went on a fast alone and asked for the nationalisation of rivers. When PMK chief S. Ramadoss decided to take on Rajnikant just before 2004 Lok Sabha elections, the actor asked his cadres to work against PMK in six Lok Sabha constituencies from where the party contested—against his own dictum in *Baba* (*Baba....enthapakkamum say-atha baba*—Baba....never takes sides). Rajnikant lost that battle, and with all six PMK candidates getting elected, it was a bitter lesson. Was it a permanent one? It's hard to tell, with former Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu inviting him to enter politics.

After all, if he can mobilise ticket sales, what is to stop him from altering political fortunes? The Boss, The Bachelor of Social Service, may just become the boss of all he surveys.

With Sandeep Unnithan, Peer Mohamed, B. Kalanidhi, and Senthil Kumar

En vazhi thani vazhi (My way, unique way)

Padayappa, 1999

films from *Gentleman to Indian* and *Anniyan*. Yet somehow he manages to do what neither Arjun, Kamal Hassan, nor Vikram have done: overshadow Shankar's special effects.

The movie gives Rajnikant 15 different hair styles, all worked on by Sandrin Varier Seth. One song, *Oru*

FAN FOLLOWING: People queue up for Sivaji in Chennai

